ITALIAN GRAMMAR LESSON · A1 · ITALIANO CON MARTIN

Italian definite articles

Learn to choose between il, lo, la, l’, i, gli and le.

https://italianoconmartin.com/en/grammar/a1/italian-definite-articles.html

What are they?

Definite articles indicate a specific person or thing: **il libro**, **la casa**, **gli studenti**.

The choice depends on three things: gender, number and initial sound of the word.

il
masculine singular, general case
il libro

lo
in front of s+consonant, z, ps, gn, x, y
lo studente

la
feminine singular
la casa

l’
before a vowel
l’amico, l’amica

Why do we say lo studente?
Because studente begins with **st**. Before s + consonant we use **lo**.

Definite articles compared with English

English has one word, the. Italian has seven (**il, lo, la, l', i, gli, le**), chosen by gender, number and the first sound of the next word. And Italian uses them where English uses nothing.

English	Italian
the book / the student / the friend	il libro / lo studente / l'amico
Coffee is good.	Il caffè è buono.
I like music.	Mi piace la musica.
Italy is beautiful.	L'Italia è bella.
on Mondays	il lunedì

- When you talk about something in general, Italian needs the article: il caffè, la musica, gli animali.
- Countries take the article too: l'Italia, la Francia, gli Stati Uniti.
- Lo and gli go before s + consonant, z, gn, ps, y: lo studente, gli zaini.

Complete table

Gender and number	Article	When	Example
masculine singular	**il**	ordinary consonant	il cane
masculine singular	**lo**	s + consonant, z, ps, gn, x, y	lo zaino
masculine singular	**l’**	vowel	l’amico
masculine plural	**i**	plural of il	i cani
masculine plural	**gli**	plural of lo and l’	gli zaini, gli amici
feminine singular	**la**	consonant	la casa
feminine singular	**l’**	vowel	l’amica
feminine plural	**le**	all cases	le case, le amiche

Examples to observe

il tavolo → i tavoli

lo studente → gli studenti

lo zaino → gli zaini

l’amico → gli amici

la porta → le porte

l’amica → le amiche

Typical mistakes English speakers make

✗ ~~Wrong: Caffè è buono.~~
✓ Correct: Il caffè è buono.
Coffee is good: general statements need the article in Italian.

✗ ~~Wrong: Mi piace musica.~~
✓ Correct: Mi piace la musica.
I like music → la musica.

✗ ~~Wrong: Italia è bella.~~
✓ Correct: L'Italia è bella.
Countries take the article.

✗ ~~Wrong: Il studente.~~
✓ Correct: Lo studente.
Before s + consonant: **lo**.

Exercises

Write the answer on the line. The answers are at the end of the lesson.

Write the correct article.

1. _____ libro

2. _____ studente

3. _____ casa

4. _____ amico

5. _____ libri

6. _____ studenti

7. _____ case

8. _____ zaino

9. _____ zaini

10. _____ amica

11. _____ amici

12. _____ amiche

Answers

1. il · **2.** lo · **3.** la · **4.** l' · **5.** i · **6.** gli · **7.** le · **8.** lo · **9.** gli · **10.** l' · **11.** gli · **12.** le

1:1 Italian lessons



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